

“Cultural Diversity in Medieval Islamic Heritage: A Study of Sufi Ethos of Kashmir”

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Abstract

The concept of Pluralism and multiculturalism and the subsequent prospects for establishment of Pluralistic Society in the global context has become an advanced discourse of contemporary academic activity. Appreciating and evaluating all discussions and conjectures about Pluralism and multiculturalism and also giving a due space to the definitions that are being assigned to it in the modern world, the roots and origin of both as a concept and as a process exist in the early Islamic period. March of scholars to the far off lands, dissemination of knowledge and learning, establishment of *Khanqahas* and *Maktabas*, the process of migration, the grand translation movement and the concept of peace and justice are some of the features essentially with Islamic orientation which encourage pluralistic view point at doctrinal and practical levels. This perspective has substantially been stimulated and propagated by sufis around the globe who have not only been the torch bearers of pluralistic perspective, acculturation, tolerance, communal harmony and co-existence in times of cultural polarization and religious animosity, but have cemented the bonds of the human integration to realize the dream of unity of mankind and universality of human culture. The contribution of Sufis to peaceful cosmopolitan civilization and cultural advancement in the promotion of communal harmony

and co-existence in shaping the history of Sub-Continent is note worthy and unprecedented.

14th and 15th centuries, in fact constitutes one of the prominent and formative phases in the history of Kashmir as it accounted for momentous, religious and cultural change. Its illustrious sons, scholars and Sufis propagated the message of human brotherhood and love that emanated from the synthesis of Islamic and Saivaite philosophies which subsequently became an indispensable and unsaggereable part of Kashmir's composite culture, the manifestation of which is found in the Sufi philosophy of *Reshis* and Sufis. It is an admitted fact, as recorded in the great historical accounts of South Asia that Mahatma Gandhi the Father of Indian Nation saw a ray of hope in Kashmir when whole Indian sub-continent was burning in communal violence and animosity. This burning candle of communal harmony was kindled through the tireless efforts of the Kashmiri Sufis. It is why the another popular name of the valley of Kashmir is *Peervar* i.e. (the Land of Sufis.) The renowned Sufis of Kashmir like Sheikh Noor-ud-din-Noorani, Lal Ded, Shamas Fakir, Ahmed Batawar, Ahad Zargar, Samad Mir, etc. throughout the course of history promoted peace, co-existence, communal harmony and pluralistic ideals. Sheikh Noor-ud-din-Noorani commonly known as Sheikh-ul-Alam while promoting the relationship between Muslims and Non-Muslims said ;(Mankind belongs to same parents therefore, no scope for animosity. Be kind to both Hindus and Muslims, it will lead to the happiness of Allah.)These Sufis in fact, lived in the midst of the lower strata of society and identified themselves with the problems and perplexities of the people.The Sayyids who arrived from Central Asia to Kashmir were ardent advocates of the Quranic injunctions and championed the cause of the poor. Hazrat Sheikh Syed Ali Hamadani commonly known as *Amir-i-Kabir* in his monumental work, *Dhakhirat al- Mulük* preached against the social evils and

problems such as unsaturated lust for worldly-things and desires, vanity, conceit, pride, cruelty, anger, vengeance, injustice, dishonesty, perfidy, jealousy, selfishness, lying, immodesty, apathy towards the condition of the poor and needy, ill treatment towards parents, wives, children, servants and slaves, without any discrimination of caste, creed, sex and religion, in so simple words and by quoting tangible and transparent common day to day examples that even an ordinary man in the street comprehended it easily. Different Sufi orders not only fought with the self-ego, but also offered a platform for peaceful co-existence and also took active part in the promotion of harmony and love. The interaction between the local traditions and the mainstream Islamic legacy gave this region the abiding values of tolerance, fellowship of faith and brotherhood as the Sufis have been great advocates and exponents of religious tolerance and horizontal humanistic values. The influence of Sufi traditions that had moulded the mind set of Muslim population for centuries together is one of the significant reason to advocate a harmonious life. *Das ba Kaar, Dil baYaar* (hand to work and your heart to God) as propagated by Sheikh Baha-ud-Din Naqshband al-Bukhari was not only the guiding force for the promotion of pluralism and multiculturalism, it stemmed down to the general masses of the region as well.

In the backdrop of these introductory remarks, present paper is an attempt

- to unfold the significance of Pluralism and Cultural Diversity that has got roots in the civilization of Islam.
- to explore the intellectual heritage of Sufi scholars to unfold their religious philosophy, world view and value system.
- to explore the intellectual treasure of indigenous Kashmiri scholars having both global and universal relevance.

- to refer to the civilizational and cultural ethos of Kashmir that emerged as a result of the contribution of prominent Iranian scholars in shaping the cultural diversity of Kashmir.